

# First Light on the Trade Way

Tuesday, 7 July 2026

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**Played:** 2026-07-07 (recorded 8:11 PM–11:06 PM ET) · **Table:** Matt (DM), Robert (Thomas A. Invictus), Anthony (Morgash the Gravemaker), Tom (Gren Greenmantle), Drew (Jetten Elisedil)  
**In-game:** one full day + one night — Daggerford → the Trade Way south → the bridge ambush site → long rest in the cave. The party wakes on the morning of day two at the turn-off to the Misty Forest. **Shards held:** 0.

## Daggerford — the Silver Gauntlet

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The campaign opened in the Silver Gauntlet, the adventurers' tavern at Daggerford's southern gatehouse, the party's last roof before the long road south. Introductions around the table:

- **Morgash the Gravemaker** — orc fighter, ex-Flaming Fist from near Baldur's Gate ("a situation I don't want to discuss right now"), a caravan guard for hire who wants one big score so he can finally retire. On hearing Thomas's story he swore it plainly: *"If there is any connection, they will feel the wrath — and you will have your back. Vengeance, I swear."*
- **Gren Greenmantle** — forest gnome sorcerer raised in the Misty Forest, sent away to a monastery when his Spellfire surfaced, outcast from his community. He found references to the shards in an old temple ledger and carries the party's map. He met Morgash defending a town and healed one of his companions.
- **Thomas A. Invictus** — human paladin of Lathander, 28, Daggerford native, former scribe. His family was murdered by thieves he'd discovered selling body parts to someone; investigating them is what uncovered the Broken Heart's existence. He suspects a necromantic connection.
- **Jetten Elisedil** — wood elf ranger, 110 years old, Thomas's childhood friend from his ranch days ("it's *your* whole life, Rob — I'm an elf"). He's on the road to support Thomas.

Lore established over drinks (Gren Survival 20, Thomas Religion 24 incl. nat 20): the green dragon is likely young or a wyrmling — no adult has been rumored; Shar is the goddess of loss, night, and forgotten memories, her faithful utterly secretive; Greenrest is a small village nobody on the road knows much about.

**The vault.** Lord Hargrove, the inn's owner, led Thomas (keyholder) to the treasure room. The party split their stored gear: Morgash took the **Ember-Touched Greatsword** (a Flaming Fist duty-blade — from his old company) and **Keoghtom's Ointment**; Gren the **Wand of the War Mage +1** and **Periapt of Wound Closure**; Thomas the **+1 Shield**, **Stone of Good Luck**, and **Cloak of Protection**; Jetten the **Quiver of Ehlonna** and both **+1 Daggers**. Roughly a thousand gold was divided (~207 each; Jetten carried a double share). Morgash left his mundane greatsword in the chest; Thomas his spare shield.

## The Trade Way south

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- **Pibb & Josk** (d12 travellers = 6): two "couriers" riding north, bickering over whether a horse needs a full night's rest. Pibb, a self-styled "respectable businessman" in documents, asked the party to arbitrate. Thomas — a scribe who knows every legitimate document-dealer in town — read him instantly (Insight 15, advantage): a forger and his accomplice. Gren quietly cast *Speak with Animals* and interviewed the horses (well-rested, fed from the apple orchard, no menace in them). The duo huffed off north unmasked but unhindered.
- **Brother Tobin**, a barefoot halfling priest of Chauntea, blessed the party and pressed a **Barley-Token** on Jetten as a kindred spirit of the wilds — with a line worth remembering: *"The lady's been strange with her gifts of late. Some fields simply cannot fail; others starve a mile off. She doesn't usually play favorites."*
- Merchants and wanderers passed; none knew anything of Greenrest beyond "a small village."

## The bridge — and the cave

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Late afternoon: an overturned merchant cart on a bridge, wheel still spinning, crates picked over, fresh blood smeared toward the riverbank. Morgash (Survival 17) picked out many booted footprints in the blood. The trail led down to an unlit natural cave.

Jetten scouted ahead in the dark (elf eyes; Stealth 18) and heard guttural laughter. Gren dropped a *Light* cantrip on poor darkvision-less Thomas — which promptly complicated Jetten's sneaking. The recon: a band of hobgoblins around a campfire, several wounded from their ambush above, with a big captain among them. The party's counsel was short. Jetten: *"As an elf I have no love for hobgoblins."* Thomas: *"We can't let them live — they'll just attack whoever comes along the road next."* Plan: Jetten snipes from shadow, Morgash and Thomas take the front, Gren supports.

Jetten's opening shot (Hunter's Mark + longbow) began the battle.

## The battle of the cave

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A long, scrappy first fight — a captain, two warriors, two archers, and (arriving from the deeper dark mid-fight) a **shaman** with a poison vine staff and Misty Step.

Highlights, in rough order:

- An archer's arrow **crit Morgash** early for 8. Thomas's **Bane** landed on a warrior and an archer — and visibly ruined hobgoblin aim all night. Gren's **Bless** propped up the front line.
- Morgash (Battle Master) chained **Action Surge** → **Precision Attack** to turn a miss into a 26-to-hit greatsword blow, later **Riposte**; on an ice-cold rolling night his Graze mastery chipped 3 damage through miss after miss. (*"Finally hit something. Finally!"*)
- Thomas smote the captain (longsword 10 + **Divine Smite** 14 radiant), and **Jetten's longbow finished the captain** from across the cave. Later Thomas **crit** an archer and dumped a 4d8 smite into it — "a holy flash of light splatters the hobgoblin archer into small bloody pieces."
- Gren built a **Minor Illusion false cave wall** and cast from behind it; with **Innate Sorcery** advantage his **Scorching Ray** volleys (two crits) burned the shaman down.
- The shaman gave as good as it got: Healing Word on a warrior, two Vine Staff hits on Jetten (12, then 9 — *"I'm almost dead"*), breaking his Hunter's Mark concentration once. Jetten's own Healing Word pulled Morgash back (10 HP — table house rule: **all healing is doubled**).
- The last warrior, surrounded, took Morgash's **non-lethal pommel strike** (a called shot to subdue) and Gren's roared ultimatum — *"Surrender or die!"* (Intimidation 13 vs. Wis 10) — and dropped his sword.

**The interrogation.** Who sent them? *"I take no orders from no one but my captain."* He looked at the corpse by the fire. *"...I am captain now."* Who did they attack? Merchants — *"that's our job."* Nothing more useful came. Jetten ended it with a shortsword thrust to the eye: *"Enough, hobgoblin scum."* (Thomas had wanted one more question; the prisoner died before he got it.)

## Aftermath — First Light

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In the back chamber lay the hobgoblins' victims, dead barely an hour: two well-appointed guards (one decapitated), a **high-elf merchant woman whose fine garb Jetten recognized as Waterdhavian** (Perception 25), and her human companion. Thomas (Investigation 21) identified the guards as **paladins of Lathander — his own god**. He prayed the psalm for the dead over them from his psalter, felt a warm wash of Lathander's approval, and refused to touch anything belonging to the faithful. His History check (17) told him the Trade Way is normally safe — these hobgoblins seemed *driven* here from somewhere, scouring land they didn't know.

The captain's blade was no hobgoblin weapon: a **Rose-Gold Longsword**, oddly warm, holding a little daylight even in the dark. Thomas felt a connection to it on sight. Attuning over the night's rest identified it: **First Light, a Dawnbringer's blade** consecrated in a temple of Lathander — +1 longsword, Heroism once per day.

Loot from the travellers' recovered chest: **Driftglobe** and a **pouch of cut gems** (Gren), **Traveller's Letter** (unsealed, addressed to someone in Daggerford — pocketed UNREAD) and **Healer's Kit** (Jetten), **hooded lantern**, rations, a bolt of fine cloth, backpack, and traveler's clothes (Thomas), two **small casks of southern wine** and a **Potion of Healing** (Morgash), plus **15 gp / 10 sp each** from the coin pouch.

The party buried the victims in shallow sword-dug graves with last rites (after briefly entertaining staking hobgoblin heads as a road-warning), burned/buried the hobgoblins, and long rested in a clean corner of the cave. Morning of day two: to the east, the treeline of the **Misty Forest** — the map says leave the road here. That's where we pick up.

## Where things stand

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- Level 3, all four PCs. No shard yet; milestone level-up comes with the first shard.
- The party has **not** yet reached Greenrest — next leg is the Misty Forest.
- Next session: Tuesday 2026-07-14. Players travel after that; the schedule breaks for a few weeks.

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Recorded at the table — transcribed & chronicled by the party scribe.